



BE READY.

Pre-season

Your sessions

Power + Prevention & health

Program

Pre-season

Duration

8 weeks

Session

45 to 60 min

Place

Gym

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Your goals

Power

Power is force multiplied by speed. A jump shot, a duel at pivot or a first step all require producing a lot of force in a fraction of a second.

- **Push heavy:** increase your maximum strength with heavy loads and few reps.
- **Move fast:** turn that strength into fast movements (throws, jumps, pushes).
- **Link the two:** pair a heavy exercise with a similar fast movement (contrast method).

The golden rules

- **Few reps, lots of rest:** 3 to 5 reps, 2 to 3 minutes of recovery.
- **Every rep at maximum speed,** even with a heavy load: the intent is what counts.
- Heavy loads only if your technique is perfect.

For heavy loads, get another person to spot you or use a power rack with the safety bars set.

Prevention & health

In handball, the most common injuries affect the ankles, knees, shoulders and the muscles at the back and inside of the thigh. Studies show that many of them can be avoided with simple exercises done regularly: a targeted warm-up roughly halved knee and ankle injuries (Olsen et al., 2005), and a shoulder programme cut shoulder problems by 28 % (Andersson et al., 2017).

- **Injury prevention:** balance, jump landings, knee control.
- **Targeted strengthening:** knees, ankles, shoulders and hamstrings.
- **Mobility and flexibility:** hips, ankles and upper back.
- **Joint stability:** keeping your joints aligned in contacts.

The golden rules

- **Consistency before intensity:** repeating the sessions is what protects you.
- **The perfect movement:** a knee caving inwards on landing is exactly what we correct.
- These exercises should not hurt: discomfort is a signal to ease off.

These exercises prevent injuries, they do not treat them. If you are in pain right now, see a health professional before carrying on.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

How to read your sessions

- Every session is written out in full, in order: do the steps from top to bottom.
- "2-4 × 8": 2 sets at level 1, 3 at level 2, 4 at level 3, of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.
- The number in front of each exercise refers to its illustrated sheet, at the end of this document.
- If you do not know your level, read the guide again, page "Choosing your level".

Weeks 1-2 · Getting started

Get your body used to effort again and learn the movements. Effort 5-6 out of 10.

Power: moderate loads to learn the movements, light throws.

Prevention & health: you learn the movements, easy variations.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

9	 Squat (moderate load)	2-3 × 6	2 min
10	 Two-handed ball throw	2-3 × 5	60 s

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

6	 Single-leg balance (eyes open)	2 × 30 s per leg	15 s
11	 Single-leg landing	2 × 5 per leg	30 s
12	 Calves: slow lowering	2 × 10	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

15	 Hip thrust	2-3 × 8	90 s
16	 Rotational throw	2 × 5 per side	60 s

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

17	 Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
18	 Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
18	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
20	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

21	 Bench press	2-3 × 6	2 min
22	 Box jump	2-3 × 4	75 s

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

23	 90/90 hip mobility	2 × 8 per side	
24	 Ankle mobility at the wall	2 × 10 per side	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

25	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
26	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
17	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week after week, you can add the optional bonus session:

Session D (bonus, optional) - 20 min

1 WARM-UP

10 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 PREVENTION AND MOBILITY

10 min

5	 Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3	60 s
23	 90/90 hip mobility	1 × 8 per side	
24	 Ankle mobility at the wall	1 × 10 per side	
27	 Upper back rotation	1 × 8 per side	

Weeks 3-5 - Building up

Increase the loads gradually. Week 5 is the heaviest. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Power: this is the phase where you push heavy, increase the loads every week.

Prevention & health: you move on to harder variations.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

28	 Heavy squat	3-4 × 4-5	3 min
10	 Two-handed ball throw	3 × 5	75 s

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

6	 Single-leg balance (eyes closed or on a cushion)	3 × 30 s per leg	15 s
29	 Single-leg squat	2-3 × 8 per leg	45 s
11	 Single-leg landing (sideways)	3 × 5 per leg	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

30	Heavy hip thrust	3-4 × 5	2 min
31	Heavy pull	3 × 5	2 min
16	Rotational throw	3 × 4 per side	60 s

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

32	External rotation, arm raised	3 × 10 per arm	30 s
33	Scapular push-ups	2-3 × 10	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
18	Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
20	Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

21	Bench press	3-4 × 4-5	3 min
22	Box jump	3 × 4	90 s

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

27	Upper back rotation	2 × 8 per side	
12	Calves: slow lowering (on one leg)	3 × 8 per leg	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

25	Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
26	Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
17	Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 6-7 · Intensity

Less volume, more speed: every rep at maximum quality. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Power: every heavy set is followed straight away by an explosive movement (contrast).

Prevention & health: exercises closer to the game, with a ball and in every direction.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

28	 Heavy squat	3 × 3	back to back
34	 Loaded squat jump	3 × 4	3 min after the pair

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

11	 Single-leg landing (diagonally)	3 × 5 per leg	30 s
20	 Balance with a ball	3 × 30 s per leg	15 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

21	 Bench press	3 × 3	back to back
35	 Plyometric push-ups	3 × 4	3 min after the pair

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

32	 External rotation, arm raised	3 × 12 per arm	30 s
33	 Scapular push-ups	3 × 10	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
18	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
20	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

36	 Overhead throw	3 × 4	75 s
16	 Rotational throw	3 × 4 per side	75 s
22	 Box jump	3 × 3	90 s

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

23	 90/90 hip mobility	2 × 8 per side	
29	 Single-leg squat	3 × 8 per leg	45 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

25	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
26	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
17	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week 8 - Taper

Repeat sessions A, B and C from weeks 6-7 doing **half the sets**, at the same intensity. You will start the season with your club in top shape.

- **Power:** Same loads, same speed.
- **Prevention & health:** One set less on each exercise.

The exercises

In the order of the numbers used in your sessions.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

1 Light jog and running drills

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: light jog, then running drills (high knees, butt kicks). Otherwise: drills on the spot or in the gym's open space: 5 minutes of high knees, butt kicks and side shuffles.

Key points: Start slowly, then gradually pick up the pace.



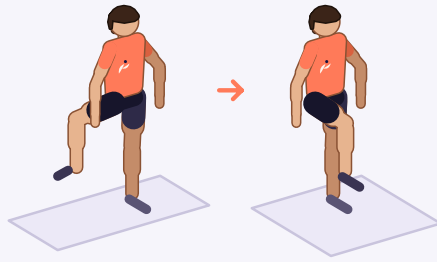
2



Forward lunge with trunk rotation

Arms straight out in front of you, take a big step forward and lower into a lunge, then turn your trunk and arms towards the front leg. Come back and switch legs.

Key points: Front knee above the ankle, slow rotation.



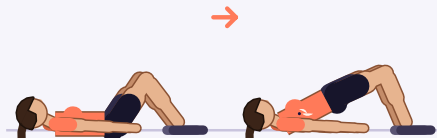
3



Walking hip opener

On the spot or walking: lift your knee out to the side as if stepping over a fence, bring it round in front of you at the same height, then put your foot down. Switch legs.

Key points: Upright trunk, big circle with the knee.



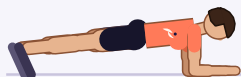
4



Glute bridge

On your back, knees bent, feet on the floor, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line, then lower.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top, do not arch your lower back. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



5



Plank

On your forearms and toes, body in a straight line from head to heels.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes and abs, breathe normally.

Easier: Knees on the floor.



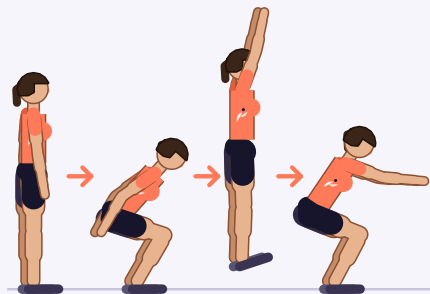
6



Single-leg balance

On one foot, knee slightly bent, the other foot off the floor behind you, arms relaxed: hold the position without moving. To progress: close your eyes, then stand on a cushion.

Key points: The knee stays over the foot, the pelvis level.



7



Small jump, stable landing

Small jump on the spot, land softly on both feet and hold the position for 2 seconds.

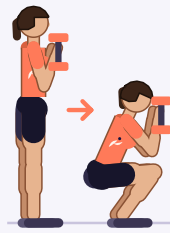
Key points: Land on the balls of your feet, knees bent and in line with your toes: they never cave inwards. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

8

Progressive accelerations

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: 3 accelerations of 5 seconds, faster each time. Otherwise: 3 accelerations of 10 seconds on an assault bike (air bike) or a rowing machine.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.

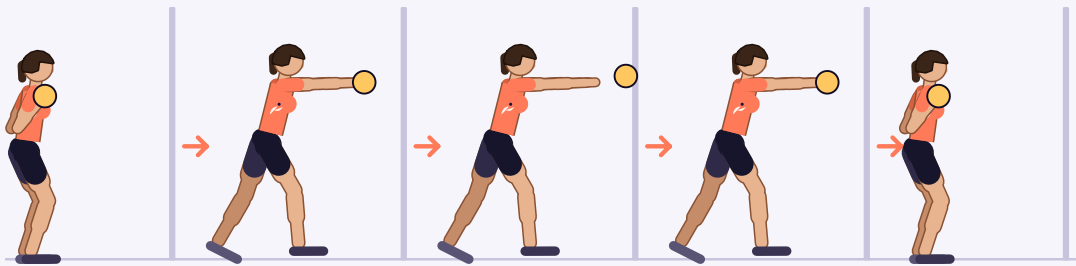


9 Squat

Feet shoulder-width apart, a dumbbell held against your chest (goblet squat), lower until your thighs are at least parallel to the floor, then stand up. Heavier: barbell on your upper back.

Key points: Straight back, heels on the floor, knees in line with your feet.

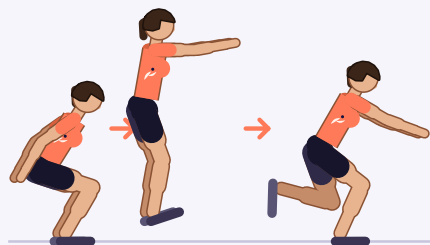
Easier: Sit down on a chair and stand up.



10 Two-handed ball throw

Facing a wall, 2 to 4 kg medicine ball at your chest, throw as hard as you can.

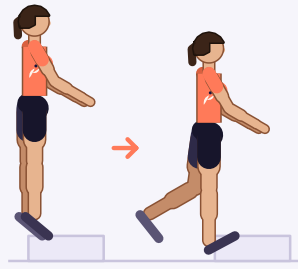
Key points: Push with your legs and arms at the same time.



11 Single-leg landing

Small hop forwards, land on one leg with the other foot in the air, hold for 3 seconds. Once you have it, also hop sideways, then diagonally.

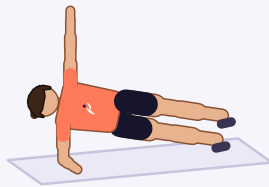
Key points: Land softly, knee in line with your foot. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.



12 Calves: slow lowering

On the edge of a step platform or a stair, rise onto the balls of both feet, then lower over 3 seconds on one foot. Harder: a dumbbell in your hand.

Key points: The heel goes below the level of the step.

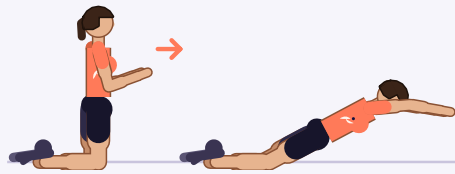


13 Side plank

On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder) and the edge of your foot, body in line, hips high, top arm reaching up to the ceiling.

Key points: The hips do not drop.

Easier: Knees on the floor.



14 Nordic hamstring curl

Kneeling on a mat, feet anchored under a loaded bench, under wall bars or held by another person, lean forward as slowly as possible, body straight. Catch yourself with your hands, then push back up with your hands.

Key points: Hips extended: the body stays straight from the knees to the head.

Easier: Shorter descent.

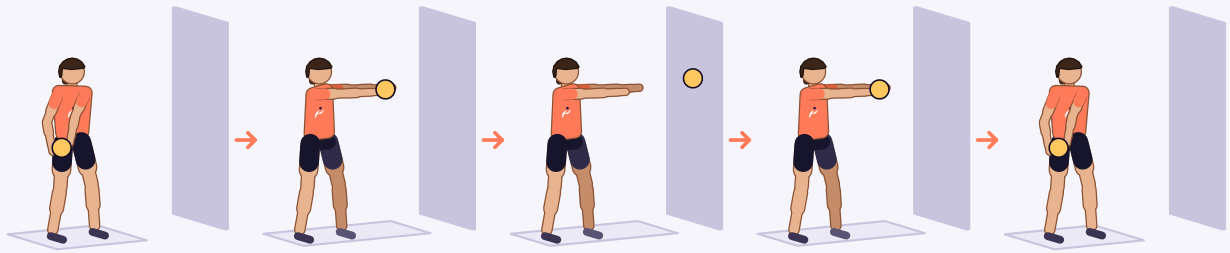


15 Hip thrust

Upper back against a bench, barbell (with a pad) or dumbbell on your hips, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top for one second. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.

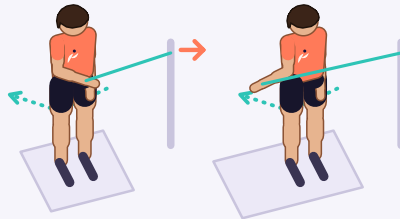
Easier: Glute bridge on the floor.



16 Rotational throw

Side-on to the wall, 2 to 4 kg medicine ball held at your hip, pivot and throw sideways, like a shot.

Key points: The movement starts from the hips, not the arms.

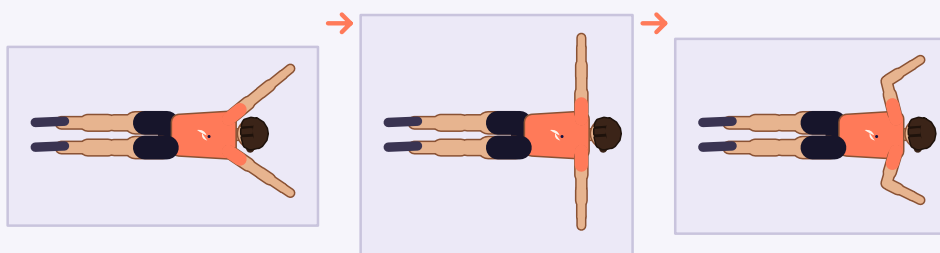


17 Shoulder external rotation

On a cable set at elbow height (or with a band): elbow tucked in and bent at 90°, move your forearm outwards, then come back slowly.

Key points: The elbow does not move, 2 seconds on the way back.

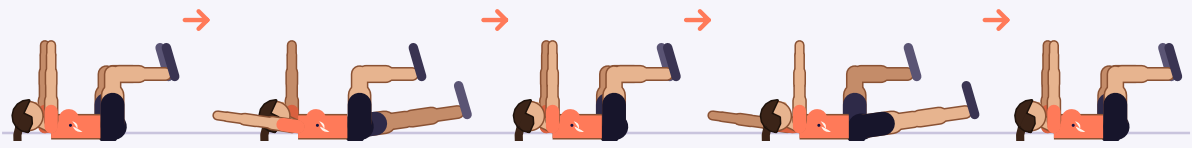
Easier: Without a band.



18 Y-T-W

Lying face down, forehead on a towel. Lift your arms off the floor to draw three letters with your body: Y (arms straight, diagonally above your head), T (arms out to the sides), then W (elbows bent, pulled in close to your ribs). Hold each letter for 2 seconds, squeezing your shoulder blades.

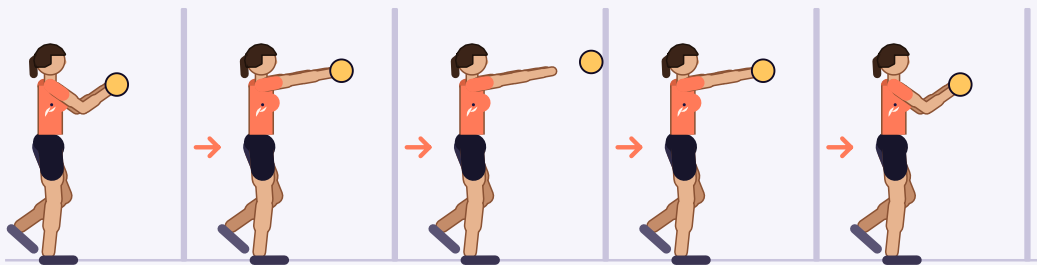
Key points: Thumbs towards the ceiling, no arching.



19 Dead bug

On your back, arms straight up towards the ceiling, knees bent at 90°. Extend one arm and the opposite leg without touching the floor, then switch sides.

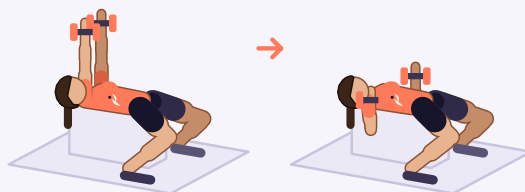
Key points: Your lower back stays pressed to the floor.



20 Balance with a ball

On one leg, throw a ball against a wall and catch it. Harder: standing on a bosu or a wobble board.

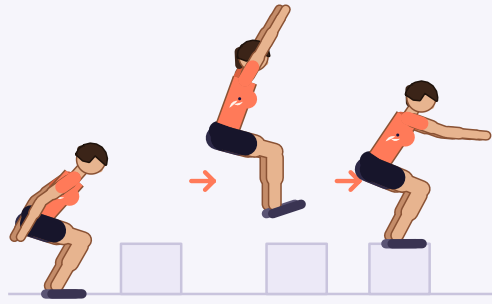
Key points: The standing knee stays in line.



21 Bench press

Bench press with a barbell (or heavy dumbbells), feet on the floor, shoulder blades squeezed.

Key points: Shoulder blades squeezed, explosive push.



22 Box jump

Jump onto a plyo box, land softly, step back down.

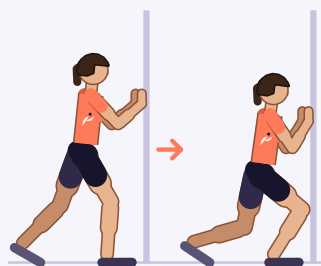
Key points: Jump high, not far. Stepping down protects your tendons. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.



23 90/90 hip mobility

Seated on the floor, hands on the floor behind you, feet flat and wider than your hips, knees up. Let both knees drop to the same side into the 90/90 position: front leg bent at 90° in front of you, back leg bent at 90° out to the side. Bring the knees back up through the middle and over to the other side, like windscreen wipers.

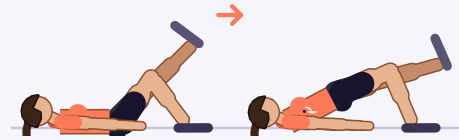
Key points: Upright trunk, slow movement. Only go as far as your hips allow, pain-free.



24 Ankle mobility at the wall

Facing a wall, hands on it, front foot 10 cm from the wall and the other foot behind: drive your front knee forward to touch the wall without lifting your heel.

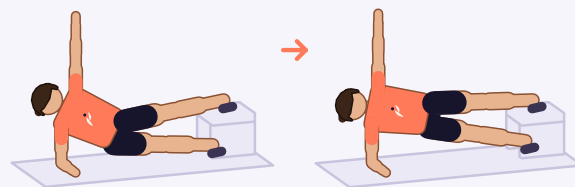
Key points: Heel glued to the floor. Move your foot back if it is easy.



25 Single-leg glute bridge

Like the glute bridge, with one leg straight in the air.

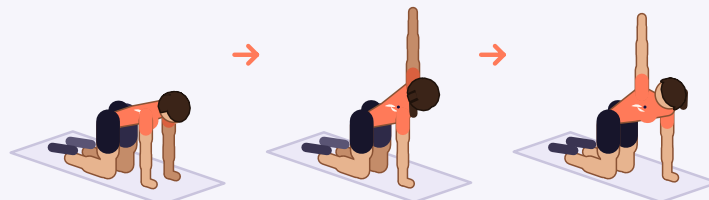
Key points: The pelvis stays level. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



26 Copenhagen plank

On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder), top leg resting on a bench (at the knee, or at the foot to make it harder). Lift your hips, reach your top arm up to the ceiling and hold the position.

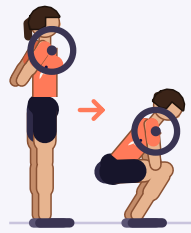
Key points: Body in line: the inside of the top thigh does the work.



27 Upper back rotation

On all fours, hands under your shoulders. Rotate your upper back as you reach one arm towards the ceiling, following your hand with your eyes, then bring it back down and do the same with the other arm.

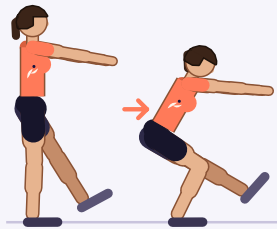
Key points: The pelvis does not move.



28 Heavy squat

Squat with a barbell on your upper back (or heavy dumbbells), 3 to 5 reps.

Key points: Controlled descent, stand up as fast as possible.



29 Single-leg squat

On one leg, the other leg straight out in front and your arms forward for balance: slowly lower into a quarter squat then stand back up.

Key points: The knee does not cave inwards.

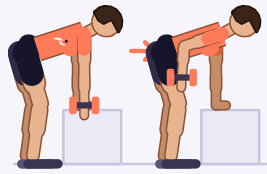
Easier: With a hand on a wall.



30 Heavy hip thrust

Upper back on a bench, heavy barbell on your hips, drive your hips up forcefully.

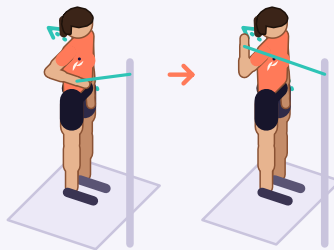
Key points: Push through your heels, lock your glutes at the top. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



31 Heavy pull

Heavy one-arm row with a dumbbell, or weighted pull-ups.

Key points: Pull fast, lower slowly.



32 External rotation, arm raised

On a cable set at shoulder height (or with a band): upper arm horizontal, elbow at 90°, rotate your forearm upwards.

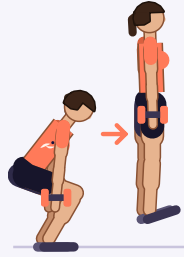
Key points: Slow and controlled, pain-free.



33 Scapular push-ups

In a straight-arm plank, squeeze then spread your shoulder blades without bending your elbows.

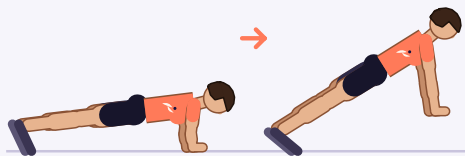
Key points: Small movement: only the shoulder blades move.



34 Loaded squat jump

Squat jump with two light dumbbells by your sides (10 to 20 % of your body weight).

Key points: Stable landing, knees in line. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

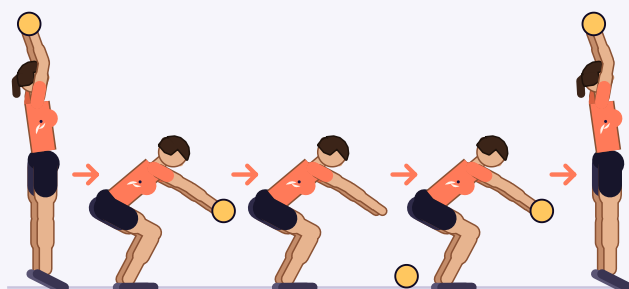


35 Plyometric push-ups

Push hard enough for your hands to leave the floor on every rep.

Key points: Land with your arms slightly bent.

Easier: Hands on a bench.



36 Overhead throw

Slam ball above your head, throw it hard into the floor in front of you as you bend your legs, then pick it up.

Key points: Your whole body takes part, tight core.